

3D smartphones?

Spice recently launched the first autostereoscopic phone, enabling 3D viewing for just ₹4,299

released OlivePad VT100 – an Android 2.2-based, 7-inch tablet with full phone functionality as well as 3G and Wi-Fi connectivity, and is priced around ₹24,000. ViewSonic owns rights to the design in some markets, including the US and Europe, and is launching it as the ViewSonic ViewPad 7. ViewSonic will also release three more tablets soon. Other manufacturers, such as MSI, RIM, Acer, LG, and Asus, all have tablet devices coming up by end 2010 or early 2011.

New phones

There were plenty of new phones launched this year, from Nokia's claim to the smartphone crown with the photo-happy Symbian^3-based Nokia N8, to the fast-spawning Android-based Samsung Galaxy S and its wide family. Other notable mobiles include the Apple iPhone 4, HTC Desire, BlackBerry Torch, Sony Ericsson Xperia X10, and Motorola Milestone XT720.

Dell made its mark in the mobile handset world this year, starting with the Streak. It also

HP acquired Palm earlier this year, and the industry was eager to know just what HP intended do with Palm's acclaimed proprietary mobile technology. HP kept mum for most of the year though, until it previewed the Palm Pre 2 – the successor to the successful Palm Pre, featuring a new and improved webOS 2.0.

Other notable mobiles introduced include the Sony Ericsson SO06, which will offer a 16.4 MP camera to users, as well as the LG L-O3C phone-camera, which is a device with the form factor of a compact digital camera.

Most Windows Phone 7 phones have received good reviews, while the operating system seems to have made quite an impression with critics and masses alike. Of course, only time and continual improvement will tell if WP7 will survive in the competition-ridden smartphone world.

Hardware

A lot of new hardware was introduced this year, from Super-AMOLED, SuperLCD, and Retina Display screens, to hardened Gorilla Glass, better cameras, and more

capable mobile processors.

Processors are becoming smarter and faster, and if anything, they require power-consumption to be optimised in the face of all that performance. While 600 MHz has become the absolute minimum clockspeed for a smart-



Mobile manners

According to a recent survey, 72 per cent people hate bad mobile phone behaviour

phone or tablet processor, 1 GHz processors first introduced in 2010 are found in numerous devices. Right now, leading processor and chipset manufacturers are all concentrating on providing the best performance per watt, whether they use System-on-Chip designs or more conventional chipset, dual-core or single-core. Current hopefuls are the ARM-designed

dual-core Cortex A9 derivatives, such as the 1 GHz Samsung Orion. Qualcomm has also announced its dual-core Snapdragon processors, due in early 2011, running at 1.2 GHz and 1.5 GHz. The NVIDIA Tegra 2 is also finally seeing some wide-scale adoption, being chosen by LG to power its Optimus lineup of smartphones.

RIM

It's been a very tough year for RIM, losing market share to Apple, Nokia, and Android devices. RIM's latest flagship phone, the BlackBerry Torch, which features its latest OS (BlackBerry 6), has not done well in global markets, and received very lukewarm reviews. However, things might be looking up in the form of the full-featured RIM PlayBook (tablet), when it releases later this year.

What 2011 will bring

2011 promises to be even more exciting than 2010, with all those new operating systems vigorously competing in the very level playing field of the global mobile market. Windows Phone 7 in particular promises to evolve further and continually better itself, providing better security features, Xbox Live

functionality, a better mobile app market, numerous new handsets, and finally, even simple copy and paste functionality. We also look forward to a whole bunch of tablets from a variety of manufacturers, big and small... Google's tablet friendly version of Android, Honeycomb, will certainly galvanise the market further.

The next generation iPad is also expected, featuring a higher resolution display, front facing camera, and a new and improved tablet-specific version of iOS4. In the Indian context, 3G is certain to bring a sea of change. All of a sudden, phones that can actually utilise the new data connections efficiently, allowing for a much better browsing experience, loads of mobile apps and value added services, more social networking and media consumption.

In terms of mobile hardware technology, we'll also see the first handsets arriving with dual core and other newer mobile processor architectures, hailing a new performance high in the mobile world, whether in the tablet, netbook, or mobile phone form factor. The Samsung Galaxy i9100S, or Google's latest Android flagship, the Nexus S, seems like it will be first such device, featuring Samsung's dual-core Cortex A9-based Orion processor.

On the software front, augmented reality will continue to grow, and as we all become more connected with 3G and 4G services, you can expect a whole world set alongside reality, providing you with information as and when you need it. Numerous developers are getting their hands dirty in this field, with the most notable being Google, with its Google Street View technology and connected search features.

All in all, 2011 sure looks like it will be an exciting time to be alive, if technology on the go is your thing. 

PLAY!

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previewed numerous other models, based on Android and Windows Phone 7, most of which will be releasing early 2011. Dell also tried its hands at selling re-branded ZTE phones in India, getting on the low-cost Android handset bandwagon.